

20210217 - Ogwo Pt 1

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Tobar: And we're beginning our interview for today, Wednesday February 17th, 2021 at 1:15 p.m. And thank you again for your participation in the project. Can you please state your name and your affiliation?

Ogwo: [13:16:07] Sure, my name is Ashley Ogwo, I am currently a PhD student at the University of Maryland.

Tobar: Wonderful. And thank you again for participating in this oral history project. I wanted to ask you about your background and your early life and any influences that were brought to bear on you by your family, their education. I'm very interested in what your early childhood was like, that sort of thing. Tell me a little bit about that and you can begin anywhere you'd like.

Ogwo: [13:16:37] OK. Well I think for me, I was always raised in a very pro black household, so just being mindful of the fact that all shades and forms of black are beautiful, that black is beautiful in every way, shape and form it comes. So that emphasis was placed very, very early on. I never had any concerns about if my race was worthy or anything like that, it was just always very pro black and pro beauty and loving yourself and loving where you come from. And so that was something that I carried on with me throughout my childhood into my college years and whatnot. So it was something that always stuck with me, just understanding the importance and the value and the amazing nature of just being black.

[13:17:42] So that was something that was very important to me growing up, especially as a Nigerian-American growing up in Detroit, Michigan, which is a predominantly black city. It was something that I always learned about through just having conversations with other people who looked like me, but may not have had the same identity as me ethnically. Being able to learn how to navigate those conversations early on, understanding what the narrative was around Africans and understanding what our narrative as Africans was around black Americans. So having those conversations early on was something that, for me, was very important. Understanding that again, within all ways that blackness appears it's something that's beautiful, something that's valued and it should be something that's celebrated however it comes.

[13:18:42] So that was something that was very instrumental in my foundation both as a child, as well as me taking that into the spaces that I now occupy.

Tobar: Wonderful. And can you tell me a little bit about your family background and upbringing?

Ogwo: [13:19:00] Sure, so my family is from Nigeria, so originally they immigrated here, my parents immigrated when they were about 20 or so. So it's been about 40 years for them since they've been in this country. I identify as an Igbo American, so Igbo is one of the main tribal groups within Nigeria. And so that influenced a lot of how I grew up. It influenced the language that I was brought up around and so I grew up in a household that would speak a mix of Igbo and

English and so with the different showings of my culture, I grew up with a different food that I was eating or different types of foods that I was eating. It was just very distinct environment to grow up in, that might not have been the same as many of my peers as I was growing up.

[13:20:01] So this was something that I spoke about when I was applying to my doctoral program, just kind of understanding the difference between me eating rice and stew at home or eating fufu at home and then going to school and it's a hamburger or pizza or things like that. I'm not saying I didn't eat those things at home, but the more readily available thing was the traditional Nigerian dishes. So that was something that, for me, was very interesting just seeing both sides of culture that was really cool for me. And so I grew up with myself and then my two brothers and my sister as well as my parents. And then when I got a little bit older, my grandfather joined us, so it was a very good – very great environment to be around, I was always happy as a kid.

[13:21:00] Having siblings that are variable in their age ranges was also something that was really cool for me, so my younger brother and I are the closest in age, three years apart. And so that was something that was always -- having these different folks at different stage of their lives, to be able to look at and see what they were doing as well as them to be able to give me advice, particularly from my older siblings, it was something that was very, very great. So that was something that was always instilled like 'look at your siblings, look at these other folks within your family who will serve as guides for you or help for you.' And then of course, my parents just being there, being present and always asking questions, being willing to sit down with us, like talk with us, those types of things. So I very much appreciated my upbringing for all that my family was able to do.

Tobar: That's awesome. And what was the occupation for your parents when they came to Detroit and were raising your family?

Ogwo: [13:22:09] So, my parents originally were both teachers, and they were teachers for a number of years and then I want to say I was a child when my father stopped teaching. So let's say, maybe six or seven or so, so my dad stopped teaching and decided that he was going to focus on – my parents had a conversation, they wanted to have at least one person having had two children before us, they wanted to have at least one person stay at home, they felt that made more sense. And so they had a conversation and my dad decided to stay home with us and so for a large part of my life, my dad was a stay at home dad. And then my mom was a teacher and my dad typically did work-related things during the summer when my mom was off and could stay home. And so then he was an ice cream man, which was really fun growing up.

[13:23:09] He did that for 25 years, so that was an amazing experience for me growing up in that type of household where one, the gender roles were not static, so being able to see that my father was more than willing to stay home and help us in whatever way, shape or form he could doing dishes, doing laundry, changing diapers – all these different things, right. So it was something that had a very profound impact on me just as a kid being able to understand that men can have different roles, they don't always have to be the quote, unquote, bread winner who goes out to work and comes back. You could have this deep connection or close connection with your father, which was something that was very important for me growing up.

Tobar: It's wonderful. And can you tell me how that spread to your experience – it's so great that you have these positive memories of early childhood. What was your experience of your neighborhood and community growing up? And can you describe any of the issues you or others may or may not have been facing in your neighborhood at the time when you were growing up that you noticed or anything that came up?

Ogwo: [13:24:24] I think in terms of my neighborhood, so again, being from a predominantly black city my neighborhood looked exactly like me. So that was something that I felt comfortable around being exposed to other people who look like me, just other black people being around just being used to seeing other black people around, was very great for me. In terms of issues, I would say I think one of the main issues for a lot of folks is always just making sure that money is good within the neighborhood as a whole, everything was being taken care of, making sure the kids are all right.

[13:25:19] Yeah, I wouldn't say there were neighborhood-wide issues, more-so folks trying to make it or folks trying to make sure that they had enough money to provide for their children or their families, in whatever form that looked like. Yeah, I think there weren't any neighborhood-wide issues that were not already tied to larger structural issues within the city. So my neighborhood was very much like a quintessential neighborhood. If we were talking about other neighborhoods, maybe or other neighborhoods around the city, that might be a different conversation. But in terms of mine, I didn't have any qualms with it.

Tobar: Right. And what era was that, if you don't mind stating the year or just to give us – no worries.

Ogwo: [13:26:20] Yeah, well I was born in '94, so I lived in Detroit up until, well I guess technically you can say, that I still live in Detroit, but if we're talking about college and going away, I was – Detroit was my primary home base up until I started my Master's program, so that was 2017.

Tobar: And what are your favorite recollections of Detroit at that time as you were growing up and leading up to your early educational experiences?

Ogwo: [13:27:03] I think I always just liked being able to go out and see so many different types of businesses, like visiting these different spaces. One of the memories I have – well I guess two, they're both school related but we would go so frequently that it was something that was kind of an ingrained part of my childhood. And one was the Northland Roller Rink, so we'd go skating and that was a school activity and we'd do that at least once a semester, so we'd probably go twice a year or so. And that was like, again, something that happened, probably from third grade all the way up until I graduated middle school with eighth grade.

[13:28:04] But yeah, that was something that was very fun, just an opportunity to kind of hang out with friends outside of school, play laser tag, do all these different things so that was really fun. And then the other was going to the Charles H. Wright African American History Museum, so that was something that I always very much enjoyed going to because it was

something that helped to put things in perspective that blackness was so much bigger than just me and my family or my neighborhood, it was something that was inter-generational, it was something that was just larger than life. And that was something that was always kind of imparted on those trips to that museum being able to see, not only depictions of Africans or African Americans, just seeing how blackness takes shape and form in various ways.

[13:29:06] That was something that we would go to the museum probably maybe once a year when I was growing up. Again, I would say probably that third grade through eighth grade timeline and I believe we took a couple trips to the Charles H. Wright Museum when I was in high school, but not as frequently. So it was something that I always enjoyed going to.

Tobar: Oh, great. And I love how you depict this image of how much of rural culture and heritage you played as you were growing up with these educational opportunities and learning moments that were happening outside of the classroom. And so let's shift to the classroom, what were your classroom educational experiences like growing up?

Ogwo: [13:29:55] I guess they were kind of interesting in the sense that I was navigating them, I guess, earlier on I was navigating them as I understood that there were certain aspects of my culture that were different. And so when I was in that, let's call it, third to fourth grade period in my life, I was very much like, yes, I want to take as many opportunities as I can to showcase my culture, my identity, where my parents come from, X, Y and Z. And so I was very adamant about any project that had to do with culture, identity, something, or choose a country to learn about, like I was always, if I could help it, choosing to talk about Nigeria or choosing to showcase various Nigerian cultures.

[13:30:55] Choosing to showcase Igbo culture, so something that always allowed me to show the beauty of the African continent, I always erred to that side, kind of thing. So yeah I think my classroom experiences were very fun. I think early on I learned that, maybe not early on, maybe reflecting back I thought, hmm, I probably did a lot of annoying things when I was younger. I think just because I wanted to – you know kids, if they learn something they want to share it with others and so I was very much that person to be like, OK, if I knew that this country in Africa was pronounced this way, I was going to share that with the teacher. And so making sure that things were called how they were. Making sure people's names were said appropriately, things like that, which in hindsight the teachers probably found annoying, but I didn't care.

[13:31:55] So, yeah I had a lot of fun with my classroom experiences in that regard. Aside from that it was just class, the same as always, going to classes like science, going to social studies, going to math, all these different things. So yeah in terms of those, I don't have any experiences that stick out more than others. I would say probably, again, they would be linked to showcasing my culture and where I come from. Probably one thing that sticks out in my head or I guess two instances, very different timelines. In I want to say, a lot of things are happening in third grade, but I feel like this was around maybe that third grade, third, fourth or fifth, one of those. But essentially we had an art project in which we got to bring in something that represented us.

[13:32:57] And I just took the opportunity to bring in pictures of – pictures that my parents took when we visited, not just Nigeria, but a couple of other countries close to Nigeria when I was a baby. So just bringing those in to showcase these huge houses, these aspects of life and vibrancy that you don't usually get to see when the African continent is depicted in America because they have very – they depict a very one-sided view of the African continent. So any opportunity that I had to showcase that, I would. So that happened in third grade where I brought in these pictures and said, 'Hey look, this is what's happening in the continent.' And then another one was I was in eleventh grade and I literally remember I went above and beyond, it was my world history class and we got to choose same thing.

[13:34:04] Getting to choose a country or whatever, a culture that we were very interested in and present on that culture. So I was going above and beyond, folks were literally just reading from a paper or bringing a couple things in class, and I literally came in with cloth, I came in with a video to showcase just various aspects of Nigerian culture, showcasing how the dress is, showcasing dancing, singing, all these different things. So it was something that, for me, was very important for me to integrate within my classroom experience because it was a very huge part of me. So it was important for me to bring that aspect and my identity into all of my classroom experiences.

Tobar: And how did that segway into secondary school and then eventually what led to the spark of pursuing college and higher education?

Ogwo: [13:35:08] For me college was always something that I was aspiring to, probably my fifth grade year I already knew that I was going to college. Fifth grade was probably the time in which I was able to conceptualize that more, but I always knew that I was going to college. It was never a question of if, it was just where? And so fifth grade I already had the understanding, while some people are like, "Oh, I really want to go to this high school," I understood that I needed to get into a good high school in order to go to a good college. So I always saw high school as more of a stepping stone than something to be super excited about, like this is a final stop for me or something that is going to be impacting my experience very broadly. I just always saw college as that goal even from that tender age of nine or 10.

Tobar: And so can you tell me a little bit about that journey, how you got to your undergraduate experience and what that was like?

Ogwo: [13:36:19] Yeah, so I applied to a lot of schools, way more than what my friends were applying to at that time, I didn't know. So I knew next to nothing about college aside from the fact that I knew I was going to go. So when it came to knowing what schools were quote, unquote, good schools, things like that, I heavily relied on my dad. And so if he said this was a good school, I was like OK, sure I'll apply. I think aside from ivy league institutions, where you already know that these are these heralded institutions, I didn't know much about college outside of the Harvard, Yale, Princeton sphere, Columbia, as well, which is ironic.

[13:37:18] But, yeah I didn't know much about it outside of understanding that there were ivy league schools which are seen as these very prestigious elite great schools. And so I relied heavily on my dad, so if he had heard of a school and thought that it was a great school

because my dad is like an education nerd, pretty much, he really loves everything that has to do with school. So if he said that it was a good school, I applied to it. And so that ended with me applying to almost 20-plus schools while my other classmates were applying to maybe five, maybe seven. So looking back, I was like wow, I didn't need to apply to all these schools, but I did anyway and so that was something that I had no working memory of this is a good school or hearing about this school outside of whatever.

[13:38:21] So a lot of that knowledge around what's good, what's not, what's seen as a reputable school, came from my dad who did a lot of just casual reading on these schools. Yeah, so for me, going to – I ended up going to the University of Michigan and this should tell you right now, I didn't even know that Michigan was a good school. So just because I didn't know anything about schools, so when folks were like, "Oh, I want to go to the University of Michigan," for me I very much wanted to go out of state and that was a very conscious decision on my part. I was like, you know I don't want it to be that my parents specifically my mom could just pop up anytime that she wants to on my campus. I would like to be informed and I felt if I stayed in the state, there was a greater chance that that would happen. So my mind was more-so focused on going out of state.

[13:39:20] So, Michigan was the only school that I applied to within Michigan, the state, and I got in and I was just like, OK. I didn't see it as that big of a deal until later on when I was having a conversation with classmates and they're like, "Oh, I didn't get in," or like, "Oh, I know all these great people who went there," and so then I was like, "Oh, wow, this is actually a reputable school." And especially for me seeing that – talking to other folks who did and did not get in and seeing differences in, let's say for example, folks would talk about, "Oh, I got a higher GPA than this other person, why did they get in?" And so it was like having those conversations about what schools are and are not, or maybe looking for, because we're all speculating at that point as high schoolers.

[13:40:21] It was very interesting, it kind of made everything seem more real. Yeah and then when it came down to my decision-making process, I feel like I have the same process with every institution that I end up going to, I go and visit the campus. I'm a very spiritual person, so I pray about it, I ask for guidance on what feels right, where I would have that experience that would move me in the directions I need to be moved. And then bam, that kind of ended up being Michigan and I felt very at peace with that decision and so that's where I was heading. So that was a very key part of it. And it's funny because my parents were very pro-Michigan before I decided to accept and go to Michigan, if that makes any sense.

[13:41:21] They were like, the main ones pushing, like yes, "look at all these other out of state schools, they're amazing," they're this, they're that. My dad was a huge fan of Emory, so when I got in he was like, "Oh, Emory is an option," and things like that. And so I think that the push for me to go out of state was very much there before I actually decided, like, hey I want to stay in Michigan, or yeah – it was – then when I decided to go to Michigan they're like, "Oh, are you sure you want to go?" They're like, "There's other schools," whereas before you heard both, right, you heard, "Michigan's a fantastic school," then you also heard like "Emory or this other school is a great school. But you should also be considering Michigan the same way that you're considering these other schools. I know you want to go out of state, blah, blah, blah."

[13:42:21] So then when I actually chose Michigan and having that like, “Are you sure you want to go to Michigan?” talk was very funny to me, it seemed kind of backwards, because I was like, “Shouldn’t you be cheering, I’m going to be closer to home and everything?” But yeah it was very funny decision making process, but I ended up where I needed to be and the folks that I met and have sustained, friendships, relationships, all those other things with are a testament to that.

Tobar: And what did you decide to pursue when you got to Michigan?

Ogwo: [13:42:59] So I decided to pursue – it has a very long name, it’s called biopsychology, cognition and neuroscience, called BCN for short. So I just usually tell people I studied biopsych because folks do not want to stick around to hear the rest of that name because it’s kind of confusing. But essentially it was a mix of biology and psychology, essentially looking at biology from a psychological perspective, so what is it that these different areas of the brain are in charge of? What behaviors do they influence, those types of things? Yeah, so I studied biopsychology, cognition and neuroscience, BCN and then had two minors, one in gender and health and one in American culture.

Tobar: And can you tell me any recollections or thoughts or memories that come up about your time pursuing that in that program and your time at Michigan as a student?

Ogwo: [13:44:10] Yes. Yeah, one, I was very involved, this is not program-wise, but more-so overall experience at Michigan, I was very involved in the African Students Association, probably my junior and senior years. I started getting involved a little bit my sophomore year, but it played a much heavier role – I was on the executive board for this association during my junior and senior years, so that was something that was very, very impactful for me just being around other folks from similar and different cultures as me. It was very interesting to be in that setting because I think a lot of times folks lump together Africans as the same, and we’re not.

[13:45:08] And so it was very good to get a chance to meet people who were from similar backgrounds who were Nigerian but not only Nigerian who were also Igbo as well as meeting people from other backgrounds, other folks who were Nigerian but they’re Yoruba or meeting folks who are from other countries, like Zambia, Zimbabwe, Uganda, Kenya, all of these different spaces; it was really great to come together and learn more about each other and our upbringing and learn – and have opportunities to discuss similarities, differences, our cultures. And then being able to showcase that on campus, so every year we had the annual culture show and that was something that was so much fun and that was actually how I ended up getting involved my sophomore year with ASA was the culture show, which is an amalgamation of dances, fashion shows, singing, comedy.

[13:46:14] All these different facets of culture that showcase the variety of African cultures that showcase just how amazing it is to embody and be in the presence of Africans. So, yeah that was something that was a huge part of my U of M experience. In terms of my program, I was very – early on when I was going to school I was premed and so that for me was something I decided very early on, even before I got to college, probably around the age of eight,

I was already saying, “I’m going to be a doc –” I was saying I’m going to be a pediatrician. And it wasn’t necessarily a tie to it, aside from seeing my pediatrician and being like yeah, she seems like she has a good gig.

[13:47:15] I like kids, but not enough to teach them, so I only had my parents, my teachers and my pediatrician as a real career guide, so I knew I didn’t want to be a teacher, because I felt like I liked kids, but not enough to spend every single day and multiple hours a day with them trying to teach them stuff. And so the other option was, oh pediatrician, she sees kids once every six months or so, and then gives them a lollypop and sends them on their way, so I was like I could do that, yeah that sounds fun. And so going into college that was kind of my mindset, “Yeah I’m going to be a pediatrician,” and I had already had a longitudinal plan of once I finish college, I’m going to finish med school, and then residency, then work a couple years at a hospital, then I open up my own private practice. My goal was always to work for myself, kind of thing.

[13:48:17] And so when I was going to college, for the first year and a half, that was really my focus, like I was studying BCN, but I knew that I wanted to be a doctor. So that was – that took up a lot of my first year and it wasn’t until – so I took a developmental psychology course my second semester of my first year, I believe and that was probably one of the classes that I had the most fun in. I didn’t really see the value of/or the importance of some of those classes I was taking that med students usually are interested in. So I took the required biology courses, but I was more interested in the ecology and evolutionary biology because I could see the application of those things readily outside in the world.

[13:49:19] Whereas most students who were premed, they were interested in the cellular molecular biology, I was just was not really into it. And so I liked having that psychology course, specifically that dev psych [developmental psychology] course was an opportunity for me to see, oh similar to what I had always liked, like seeing those applications of these different behaviors in life, right. So being able to learn about childhood development, how folks develop from childhood to adulthood. What are these significant stages that folks go through? How does that look similar or different depending on these various identities? So that was the first course that I was ever excited to go to, those other classes I was taking, like pre-calc or calculus, all these other things, I wasn’t necessarily into.

[13:50:20] But the psych course, I just remember I missed a class and I was so sad about missing that class and I had never had that feeling ever, because I was never that person within school. So I did great in school, doesn’t mean that I enjoyed going to class and I feel like there’s very few people who say they genuinely enjoy going to class. So that, for me, was an eye opening experience, so that tested the water in a sense for me to think through, what are other things that I’m interested in, that I have not explored yet while I’ve been at Michigan? Into that, then probably my second year was when I started thinking through – I started taking other classes, so my American culture – my first American culture class that I took, before I decided I – as soon as I took that course, I decided I was going to get a minor in it.

[13:51:20] But it was called “From Harems to Terrorists” and it looked at the depictions of Arabs and Muslims in the media over time, how that shifted and changed to fit certain

narratives. And I loved that course, I loved my professor and it was just – it was an eye opening experience in more ways than one, just because I had not really thought in depth about the depictions of other individuals aside from black people within media. I had not – I knew how they depicted black people in media, but I was never thinking about how others were depicted and how that shifted or changed to fit certain agendas within the U.S. It was something that, for me, I was like wow, I need to educate myself on other people, and so it was an opportunity to explore different facets of American culture that, if you think about the term even American culture you wouldn't think about.

[13:52:24] Like you wouldn't necessarily think about, like OK, this minor would be looking at race and mixed race, would be looking at the depiction of Arabs and Muslims in media, would be looking at Latinx individuals within American contexts. So all these different things that folks wouldn't necessarily think about or people that they wouldn't necessarily think about when they think about America, that's what I was getting a chance to learn about. So that was something that, for me, was like – I was having a lot of fun learning about it, it was rigorous work and demanding work and very much necessarily self-reflective work, but I really, really enjoyed it. And so taking those classes and seeing the difference in myself and how I responded and interacted within those classes compared to the ones I was taking as a premed student, I had to come to a decision of like, what is it that I actually enjoy doing?

[13:53:28] And what do I want to do, what do I see myself doing for a good chunk of my life? And after a while of just reflecting, praying about it, just thinking about it, I had to come to a point in which I was OK with letting go of medicine because it just wasn't that thing that sparked for me the way that these other aspects of talking about culture, talking about identity, talking about race, all these other things, it wasn't that same spark as it was with those. So it forced me to, as I was doing these other classes within my last two years, shift my focus, but I wasn't 100% sure if I wanted to give up medicine or not, I was still combating it, even though I did want to let it go. I was like, OK, but I've been saying this for so long, so if I don't do this, what else would I do?

[13:54:28] And so I spent those last two years really just thinking about what are my alternatives? What is it that I can make a career out of if I don't do this thing? So yeah, so that was a lot of the in-class experiences that I had, they were still very much enjoyable because once I started taking these classes full-time that I really loved, it made that experience a lot easier. But again, in terms of deciding career things or where I wanted to go after college, that was still up in the air. But that was aided after I graduated and heard more about, one higher education as a field to pursue because I didn't understand that it was something that I could pursue as a practitioner or a scholar. I just knew that we were in higher education as college students, yeah I know about higher education, but I never thought of it as a field I could pursue and definitely not something I could get a Master's degree in.

[13:55:30] So, yeah that was kind of my experience at U of M very challenging aspects of it, but also great aspects of it in terms of my connections with friends, some of the faculty that I met, staff that I met, yeah so it was very much a, you take the good with the bad type of thing.

Tobar: And it's so interesting that you – listening to your story as you're telling it, how much of a hold the social and political contexts of culture had on you ever since you were very little and carrying that over, I was there the whole time. And it manifested itself until you couldn't deny it any longer when you graduated from U of M. Were there any folks that were really useful guideposts for you along the way in that journey? Any faculty that stood out? I know you had mentioned a couple of classes that you thought were imperative towards your own personal and intellectual development as a emerging scholar, maybe you have some names that pop up in your mind as well as maybe fellow classmates.

And how did that transition to you, higher education being that viable option? I'd love to know more about that journey.

Ogwo: [13:56:54] Yeah so I, for the life of me, cannot remember what my dev psych [developmental psychology] teacher's name was, but she was amazing and I – while I knew that I didn't want to be a developmental psychologist, she was one of those people that I saw – one of the first people that I saw that teaching could be fun from, if that makes sense. She was one of the first professors that I had that I was like, oh, you can come and enjoy a class because you're learning something that you care about or are interested in. And she made the class very fun, very interactive and especially that was very difficult to do because we were in a lecture hall of 150-plus people and so somehow she still found a way to make it more interactive, more engaging in several ways.

[13:57:59] So it wasn't always just like a lecture, sometimes she'd bring in videos, or sometimes she'd bring in guest speakers, or sometimes she'd talk about cases and we'd do case studies, things like that. And even the homework or assignments that we had to do were things that really emphasized the multidisciplinary or interdisciplinary nature of the work that we do. And so doing things like reviewing movies, I had never heard of coding in that way until I had gotten to that class, so coding, when I thought of coding, I thought of computer science. And so I was like, what's coding in this sense? I am not a CS [computer science] student, so how are we going to do coding? And she was talking about data coding. And I just was like wow, you can do coding in these different ways.

[13:58:59] So I remember doing coding for a movie to figure out, I believe it was like overt romantic interactions and overt romantic intentions that folks displayed. And so counting the amount of times that someone was staring deeply into another person's eyes. Or hugging another person or kissing another person, all these different things that display romantic intentions. And I was like, this is very interesting that this is like, I can do this as I'm watching a movie that I can enjoy, but I'm like doing work for it. So she was very much a catalyst for me being able to see professors as folks who could engage in more ways than one, but also having the opportunity to look at assignments in a different way, doing something that could be fun and interesting for you.

[14:00:02] So, she was a very huge part of that and I wish I did remember her name. Aside from that, Dr. Evelyn Alsultany, she was the professor that I mentioned for my "From Harems to Terrorists" class. And then I went on to take a couple more classes with her including race and mixed race and she was just an amazing human being in general. And I very much just

enjoyed having conversations with her; she was a very huge push for me to just – because when I came into her class I was still on the fence as how I was thinking through medicine and things like that. And so being in her classes, I saw just by the nature of my interactions and how I responded in those classes.

[14:01:03] I very much cared about talking about issues of race, or talking about black people, talking about black cultures, talking about identity and the role that it plays for people in general, students, yes, but also just we're people first and then students second. So seeing the role that it plays in folks' day to day interactions, all these other things, being in her classroom, very much brought a lot of that out of me, I noticed the differences in my engagements within her class or other classes of that nature compared to, like I said, the science or the math classes I was taking. So there wasn't that same pull for me with those classes, so yeah she played just a huge role in just being –

[14:02:02] She didn't care whatever I pursued anyway. She was just like, "Yeah you can do whatever you want to do, I believe in you whatever way you decide to go." And so she was very happy to whatever I ended up pursuing, write me a letter or recommendation or do all these other things and so she was a huge component of me understanding that there were various things that I could be interested in at the same time and that was OK.

Tobar: It's so important to have people like that in your life as you're starting to form your intellectual identity. To let you know that it's OK to have multiple interests and they may obviously intersect. Right? So tell me more about how that segway into you getting interested in higher education as a field, as a practitioner?

Ogwo: [14:03:06] Yeah, so when I was about to graduate, I was also involved from my sophomore year to my senior year in a program called the Global Scholars Program, GSP for short. And so being in GSP – when I first started there was a different director but the assistant director ended up, like once I got into my junior year the assistant director became the director. And so having conversations with her actually when I was about to graduate and then when I graduated was actually like that point of clarification and maybe that aha moment, if you want to think about it that way for me to say, "Wow, higher education is something that I would be interested in reading up on and potentially pursuing."

[14:04:10] So, I essentially had a conversation with her about what is it that I want to do after I graduated and that was something that she had asked me, "What do you want to do? What do you see yourself doing?" and I told her, I see myself talking to students, engaging with students, doing a lot of things that I had already been doing in my classes, but just on a larger level, if that makes sense. Being able to engage with students, help students in whatever way, shape, or form that I could, whether that was helping them to navigate their relationships within college, helping them to navigate their academic pursuits, helping them to navigate what it means to find out what you actually really want to do.

[14:05:04] And finding out how to help them navigate if that's something that you want to do different than what other folks expect of you, or your parents or whomever, family expects of you, how do you go about navigating those conversations? I just like wanted to engage with

students and so she was like, “So what you’re describing to me is higher education,” and I’m like, “I mean yeah because we’re in higher education. So yes I’m describing that to you.” And she was like, “No, you’re describing the field of higher education as a field of study and a field of practice,” and I’m like, “Hmm, OK, tell me more about this thing.” And so she’s like, “Literally within higher education you can do whatever you want, you can do a lot of things and you will still be helping students in some way, shape or form.”

[14:06:02] And so she was the one who really told me about – her name was Robbie Routenberg and she was the one who told me that higher education is something that you can pursue and she told me about her experience because she had gotten her Master’s within higher education. And so she was the first person that told me about it as a potential field in and of itself to pursue. Yeah, so that was how I learned about higher education and then with doing my own research afterwards, I was like, oh wow, there’s a lot that you can do with this and this actually was what I was describing when I was talking to her. So something that’s important for me like I don’t just take things that folks say at face value, I always have to do my own digging with it as well. And so after looking into it more, it sounded great when she was saying it.

[14:07:04] But a lot of things sound great, like when some folks are able to tell you about their passion within it and so doing my own digging and being able to look into what higher education as a field was, really sparked that interest for me. And so with that, I had to use that – I took a gap year between my undergrad and my Master’s and I used that year to really figure out what is it that, for the first half of the year, figure out what it was that I wanted to do. Because another interest of mine, potentially, was public health and so I was still deciding, like do I want to do public health, do I want to do higher education. Was my interest in public health to still tie me to the health field in general, if I didn’t want to do medicine? So I really had to do a lot of interrogation of that. And so when I did and just thinking about it, praying about it, going to visit these different institutions.

[14:08:05] So I was very fortunate to do like my family, we did a road trip kind of thing looking at certain colleges that I was potentially interested in within states that I was potentially interested in living while I was doing my Master’s. So we took a trip to Texas and California and that was a very interesting trip just to get to know more about these fields of study. And so I always found myself, even on those trips, more drawn to learning about higher education than I was to learning about public health, just because the people that I met were fantastic within that discipline. And so they were always very much willing to help – they were very open and honest about their experiences, both at the college, as well in the field and so that helped me to really make my decision.

[14:09:08] And so once I made my decision it was more-so about explaining my decision and why I felt the way that I felt to my parents. And so that was a very lengthy process, a taxing process, but once they read when I was applying to schools, and once they read my statement of purpose or whatever you call it, personal statement, that’s when they started understanding why I was pursuing what I was pursuing. And so that was when they really were able to get fully behind me on wanting to pursue higher education as an avenue. And so them getting that chance to read about my passions and why I felt the way that I felt about helping students, that was

something that they were like, “Oh, OK, now I get it,” and so having their support was super huge to me.

[14:10:10] Because I didn’t want to do anything that I felt I wouldn’t get that familial support or backing from and so it was important for me to have them along the journey with me. And so I was very happy to see the culmination of my efforts as well as the talks with them and also my personal statements, like how that impacted them and how that helped them to see there are other fields of pursuit that are equally as important as being a doctor, being whatever. And so it was something that, for them, once they saw that passion in writing, they knew that it wasn’t just something that was, like, oh, OK, maybe I’ve made a decision not to pursue medicine because like oh, I didn’t – it wasn’t – they saw it wasn’t a flippant decision after they read those statements.

[14:11:11] So having their support was very, very crucial for me to continue on and just know that I can call them at any point in time, have a conversation with them, just about how I was feeling and things like that. So, yeah, so my journey to higher education was very, it wasn’t a straight journey but it ended up being with all the winds and curves and spins that it took, got me to where I needed to be, which was TC.

Tobar: And tell me about how you ultimately made the decision to consider TC amongst, I’m sure – If there was any indicator of what you went through for your undergraduate experience, I’m sure you also have some really high – other options that you were also measuring. So maybe you could share a little bit about that.

Ogwo: [14:12:02] Yeah, so I applied to three programs for my Master’s, I applied to Northwestern, I applied to TC and I applied to University of Michigan where I got my undergrad degree from. I was very fortunate to get into the three of them and so my decision making process was very similar to my decision making process for undergrad, to be able to visit as many of these schools that I could. And so I went to the Admitted Students Days for each of those three schools and it’s funny because off the bat, I had loved Columbia since I was a high schooler. I didn’t mention this, but essentially when I was deciding where I wanted to go for undergrad.

[14:12:57] And even the schools that I was interested in, we – my family and I took a road trip, we do a lot of road trips, so we took a road trip to visit these ivy league institutions and so I got to visit and see all of the ivy league institutions and my favorite by far was Columbia. I was in love with just the vibe of it, how it was, it was small but also within this larger expanse of a city. It was just something that I could literally see myself going there. And so when I applied and I didn’t get in, I was sad about it, but looking back, I was like ‘literally it was divine intervention.’ Because had I gone out of state my undergrad year I don’t know what type of person I would’ve been.

[14:13:52] Because those years at Michigan and those conversations and interactions, the people that I was around, very much shaped who I am today as well as how I approach having certain conversations. And so yeah I was always interested in Columbia, but it’s funny because then when I got in, I was like – I’m also a person – I don’t like when things feel like they’re

being sold to me, right. So I don't just make the decision because that's popular. So I didn't want to choose TC just because it's Columbia and just because of the name and just because I was interested in it before. I was like, "no, I need to make a very clear decision based on how I'm feeling when I go to these institutions, what I know about them, X, Y and Z." So I had made that very clear, even when I got in.

[14:14:49] And so when I went to Northwestern's Admitted Students Day first and it was just like, I wasn't feeling it. I didn't want to make a decision about where I was attending school and feel like I had to settle in one way, shape or form. I wanted it to be a holistic experience for me that I would enjoy. And so at Northwestern I would've been one of, I don't know, when I walked into the room I was the only black person who was there, who was not already there. There was another current student who – she was a black woman and I was just like, OK, there's no one else around me that is black and that's a problem. And so for me, being able to see folks who look like me was something that was very important, I was not going to compromise on that.

[14:15:54] And so I didn't like the fact that it took me literally, I went with my mom to visit these schools and so particularly visiting Northwestern with her, we were driving and literally it took us until the second day to see a black person on campus. And it was just like, that's a very sad thing to picture and so I didn't want that to be my experience. I would've had a fantastic internship, because I very much bonded with – I would've had an internship with their study abroad office. I had very much bonded with the folks who were in charge there and so that would've been an amazing experience. But again, within the other facets I did not feel that connected to it. So I met the other folks who would've been my potential cohorts and they were more-so interested in talking about partying or drinking and these other things that I was just not interested in talking about.

[14:17:03] And so I was like, OK, that's not something that I would want to get into. And then on top of that, having a conversation with the black woman who was in the program and she had upfront asked me, "Do you have a vested interest in coming here?" And I was like, "I don't know, hmm," and she was like, "Because I will not recommend it to other black people." And I was like, "OK, well if you're saying this, I don't need to hear it twice." So it was very much like a deciding factor for me to be like, OK, I would've loved my internship there, but again, I didn't want to settle and I would've most definitely been settling in terms of the environment racially as well as the environment socially with my classmates. And so the next Admitted Students Day that I went to was the University of Michigan.

[14:18:01] And I had already gone in telling myself, "OK, do not compare it to your undergrad experience here; these are different people, do not hold them to the same issues that you had with the institution at the undergrad level." And so going in there I tried to come in, give it an – not an unbiased review, but one that was not biased by my previous experience at the institution. And it was OK, I feel like I spent more time bonding with people who were likely not going to go there. Or having conversations with professors who had just moved there, weren't even established.

[14:18:54] So I remember talking to one student who was visiting from California and she had also gotten into UCLA and having a conversation with her and she seemed like a very dope individual but I just told her, I was like, “Listen, if you’re getting –” and she was telling me Michigan was more expensive and there was less funding for her than UCLA. And I was like, “If you are able to get in-state tuition, pay less out of pocket, your family is there,” all these different things, “You need to be at UCLA. Do not travel all the way here for the Michigan experience, you can build your own experience at UCLA.” And so reflecting on myself, you know kind of dissuading other people from going to the institution, I was probably like “ha, so maybe I shouldn’t go here either if I’m already telling people not to go here.”

[14:19:53] And another part was, again, just having conversations with some of the folks I was very interested in learning from and it wasn’t – the conversations weren’t what I was expecting. They weren’t as, that ah-ha moment or that breath of fresh air that I was expecting. And so the faculty member that I did connect with; she was coming from another institution and she hadn’t even bought her house yet. And so I was like, “hmm, if I’m not connecting with folks who are already established here, what does that say about what my experience would be like here, kind of thing?” And so my Admitted Students Day experiences at both Northwestern and U of M were very lackluster.

[14:20:45] And so I just remember praying, like “Lord, if TC is this exact same way, I don’t know how I’m going to make this decision, because it’s going to be me deciding between three schools that I’m not that excited about.” And so when I got to TC, it was like night and day. Literally it was like going to those others, I didn’t feel that connection and when I got to TC it was like that instant connection. If anything, I was being more stubborn than I needed to, because it was a very easy decision after going through the HPSE [Higher & Postsecondary Education] Admitted Students Day. And it was like, I was having meaningful conversations with folks who I didn’t even know. I just remember I was sitting in a room waiting for our breakout sessions and literally having conversations with folks some of whom ended up being in my program and then some of whom did not.

[14:21:54] But we were just like talking about education and the state of it and how do we improve? And what can be done to help black and brown students? Just these huge questions and conversations to be having with folks who you just met and I loved it. I was like this is amazing, this was the conversation I was looking for at Northwestern, at U of M, all these other things. Right? On top of that, I wanted a place that emphasized diversity and did not just try to market it as a selling point, I wanted them to actually be invested in the students who they were trying to attract, the diverse students they were trying to attract. And I went to the HPSE breakout session and literally was blown away by the faculty. And I tell people all the time how ironic it is, because our faculty were mostly white and they were some of the most straightforward about their interest within diversity, inclusion, equity work.

[14:23:03] How to make spaces better for individuals of color. How to – their interests were genuine, it wasn’t something that was staged. I remember Noah, Dr. Drezner talking about just the fact that the reason why he then decided to pursue his PhD was – or just pursue a career in research, was that when he was fundraising, he noticed that black alumni did not give back to their institutions at the same rates as other groups, other racial groups. So when he brought this

question of why black people don't give back as much, black alumni don't give back as much, the response that he got from his supervisor, he did not just take that and sit down with it. The supervisor was like – and he [Noah] will tell you this, the supervisor was like, “Yeah they just don't give back as much, maybe they just don't care.”

[14:24:08] And he was like, “There has to be more to it than that, there has to be more to it.” So he wanted to do more research on black alumni, like their relationships with their institution and how that impacted their giving and their donations, things like that. And so he found that these black alumni weren't giving back because they didn't have great experiences at these institutions, so why would they continue to funnel money into them? And so had he just taken the word of his supervisor, there would be no Noah as we know him today, right. And so it was just like, the genuine interest of our faculty in issue of equity, issues of representation, things like that, was so genuine that I was very much drawn to it.

[14:25:04] And like I said, I don't like when things feel like they're being sold to me and I never got that perception at TC. Our faculty didn't say this, but this was basically what they were insinuating, we would love to have you – speaking to the whole room, not just me – but we would love to have you and you would add greatly to our cohort, at the same time, we're still going to continue doing these things that we're very much interested in doing and pursuing because this is what we care about. And so it was kind of one of those things where it was like if you come, great, if you don't, it's sad, but we're still going to continue doing what we do. And that was something that I was like, OK, that's phenomenal, because you are actually invested in this work then.

[14:26:01] You're not just trying to sell me the dream of having a diverse cohort or having these experiences that mean something to me as a student of color. Another point at TC where I felt like, “OK this is it,” was I remember going to a session afterwards that I want to say this was during the Academic Festival maybe, that was the next day. And literally there was a student who asked a question and he was like, it was something about essentially the white savior complex. And he was like, “How do you –” because the session was talking about the – some programs that were happening for black and brown students, so his question was like, “How are you all making sure that you're not perpetuating the white savior narrative?”

[14:27:03] And the fact that they didn't immediately shut him down, I was like, “oh.” Because I'd never been in a space in which folks were asking questions like that very bluntly. I'm like, people of color we're going to talk about it in our own spaces, amongst our own people, but I didn't know that other folks were bringing these things readily to white people's faces in this case. And like the fact that they were like, “You know that is something that we're continuously thinking about or working on, and we're doing this and that, but we're still open to learning, understanding that there are ways that we might be perpetuating a narrative in ways that we don't intend to. And that's why we always welcome feedback from our students, from the folks who are in it with us, dah, dah, dah, dah.” And so I was like, wow they didn't immediately shut him down or say, “oh no we're not doing that,” this, that and the other.

[14:28:04] So it was very beautiful to see the willingness to have these difficult conversations, right. Because no one likes being called out, especially in terms of being accused

of being a white savior. So it was like the fact that they were willing to have these conversations was something that was very, very special to me about the institution. And then lastly it was having a conversation with a current student because I was very hesitant about leaving home because I was a source of support for my family, as well as I wanted to make sure that if they ever needed something, I was close by and so I was very hesitant to leave Michigan.

[14:28:55] And I had a conversation with another student who had been in a similar situation as me who – she was graduating and so she had spoken on the current student panel and I had asked her, “How did you deal with leaving your family?”, things like that. And this was after the session had already ended, we were like done for the day, we’re at the HPSE social now. And so it’s funny because I wasn’t even supposed to be at the social; I was already – in my head I was like I’m tired, I want to go home or at least I wanted to go to the hotel. And so my parents were late picking me up, which if they hadn’t been late, I would not have had the opportunity to talk to her. And literally she put those fears that I had at ease, because she was like, “Look, we both love our families, that’s not a question.

[14:29:59] Whether you are here or not, you still love your family and you still want the best for them, go and get what you need to help continue to support them.” And so she was saying, “Look, it’s only a year, maybe two years. If you are that pressed you can go right back home afterwards,” and so that really stuck with me and then another thing that she said that stuck was like, “Give your family the chance to be all right without you, give them that chance to show that they will be fine.” And I was just like, huh, because I was really holding on to that narrative of like, they need me, they need me. And so that “give them the chance” was something that I was just like, “OK, I can do that, I can step away. Again, it’s only a year or two years, whatever.” So that was very impactful for me, her saying that.

[14:30:54] And that just when I came back home reflecting on the overall experience and it was funny having a conversation with – who would be my cohortmates, everyone I was having a conversation with in the circle, they’d already paid their deposit, were coming to TC and I was like, “Yeah I’m still deciding,” and literally their question was, “What are you waiting for?” And so I held that question until I got back home and literally comparing my experiences across the three institutions, thinking through what I’d seen and what I valued within my decision making process, I did ask myself that question. Like, “What are you waiting for?” Neither of the other schools that you were considering held a candle to what you experienced at TC, so why the hesitation?

[14:31:48] And so I hit accept for the offer and I didn’t look back.

Tobar: Absolutely awesome story. I love it. We’re reaching the 2:30 mark in the interview, I think that given the segway and we could schedule a follow up to go through the rest of these questions, if that works for you. Or we can try to squeeze in one more question, which may go over time a little bit. What do you feel comfortable with?

Ogwo: [14:32:23] Well, I guess a question would be, what would the question you want to go to be?

Tobar: – I guess going into basically now we're going to be shifting to your experiences at TC as a graduate student at TC. So I feel like this is a wonderful way to segway into the next theme of questions. I'm comfortable with whatever you want to do, I don't want you to feel rushed, so maybe perhaps if we paused now and then when we schedule a follow up we could continue with that train of thought and continue the narrative. I wish we didn't have to stop, but I also want to be considerate of the time and energy and so whatever you feel comfortable with. But I'm feeling like now would probably be a good time to pause and we can resume a part two if you feel OK with that.

Ogwo: [14:33:10] Yes, that sounds good to me.

Tobar: Awesome, so I'm going to pause the recording and I'm going to ask you to pause the phone recording. And we will see you for part two soon.

Ogwo: [14:33:19] OK, awesome.

[End of recorded material, 14:33:20]